



UNIT I

The Nation Turns West — and the Cities Rise

The Rise of Industrialization · 1877–1900

US.01

US.02

US.03

US.04

US.05

US.06

US.07

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

As America industrialized, the same forces — the railroad, the factory, the open door — meant opportunity for some and loss for others. Whose America was being built, and at whose expense?

Between 1877 and 1900 the United States remade itself - steel and steam, a railroad stretched from sea to sea, cities swelling with people from everywhere. It was the country's great engine turning on. But an engine that powerful lifts some people and runs over others, and this unit asks you to watch both at once. You'll ride along with five young people who lived it - a homesteader, a Lakota teenager, a Black Tennessean chasing freedom west, an Italian girl in a New York tenement, and a working-class newsboy - and you'll hear from real voices like Ida B. Wells and Zitkala-Sa in their own words. Your job isn't to memorize that the era happened. It's to decide, from the evidence, whether the country was climbing toward its own ideals or slipping away from them - and to notice how ordinary people forced it to climb.

How this unit works

- Taught through story - you meet a person before an abstraction, so it sticks (and shows up on the test).
- Multiple perspectives - as many voices as the history warrants, each represented fairly; you weigh them.
- Primary sources - every claim is tied to a real document, photo, or cartoon you can examine yourself.
- UDL - a present-day hook, plain-language summaries, images with alt text, and a choice of ways to respond.
- The civic cycle - see how a raised voice (press, protest, a vote) pushes the government to act.
- The Arc of the Union - plot this unit's climbs and setbacks on the course-long trajectory you build all year.

Flight crew this unit:

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

Who you'll travel with in this unit



Anna Halvorsen, 15
Dakota Territory
(family emigrated
from Norway)



Chaska, 15
The Northern Plains
(Lakota)



Isaiah, 18
Left Tennessee for
Kansas



Rosa, 15
Arrived at Ellis Island;
a Lower East Side
tenement, New York
City



Frankie, 14
New York City

Spread 1 • US.01

Analyze how the Homestead Act and the transcontinental railroad drove westward settlement, and why the same expansion was opportunity for settlers and dispossession for Native nations.

🔊 Here's the deal: move onto 160 acres, live there five years, plant something — and the land is yours. Free. Forever. No catch. Except the "empty" land was somebody's home first, and clearing them off was the actual plan. The U.S. government ran that offer about 1.6 million times. Read both sides of it — then tell me you'd have signed.

The C-130 drops the crew onto an ocean of grass, Dakota Territory, 1878. Archive kills the engines and lets the wind do the talking. 'The government's giving this land away — 160 acres to anybody willing to farm it,' she says. 'Looks empty. It isn't. Meet two people standing on the exact same dirt.'



ERA-FRIEND

Anna • a homestead claim on the plains

Anna's family crossed an ocean for one sheet of paper. Live on the land five years, break it, build on it — and it's theirs. Back in Norway, people like them never owned anything but their own two hands. The work out here is merciless: sod for walls, grasshoppers for weather, a sky that keeps forgetting to rain. But her father stands in his own doorway now, on his own ground, and for the first time in his life nobody on earth can put him off it. To Anna, the West is the biggest promise she has ever heard. She doesn't know yet that the grass under her boots already remembers other names.



ERA-FRIEND

Chaska • this land is not empty

Chaska stands on the same grass and sees the exact opposite of empty. This is where his grandparents are buried. This is the road the buffalo walk. For longer than anyone can count, this has been his people's ground — and now men with chains and survey stakes are chopping it into 160-acre squares for strangers who crossed an ocean to get here. When Anna calls the land free, Chaska hears the trick hiding in the word. It was called free because somebody in a faraway office decided his people didn't count as its owners. Same dirt. Two truths. Only one of them came with a piece of paper.



📷 Golden Spike Ceremony at Promontory Summit, Utah, May 10, 1869 — completion of the first transcontinental railroad.

Russell, Andrew J. Golden Spike Ceremony at Promontory, Utah. 1869. Photograph. National Archives and Records Administration, 594940.

💡 Everyone in this famous photo is celebrating. Ask: who is not in the picture? Whose land and labor made this moment possible but were left out of the frame?

In plain words: The Homestead Act gave settlers free land, and the railroad (finished in 1869) made the West easy to reach. For immigrants like Anna, this was a huge opportunity. But that 'free' land already belonged to Native nations like Chaska's, who were pushed off it. The same event was a gift to some and a loss to others.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee helped power the westward push. Nashville grew into a major rail hub - the Nashville, Chattanooga & St. Louis Railway - and Chattanooga was called 'the Gateway to the South.' And it wasn't only white settlers heading west: in 1879, thousands of Black Tennesseans - the 'Exodusters,' led by Nashville's Benjamin 'Pap' Singleton - rode those rails to Kansas looking for land and safety.

✓ **Check:** Anna and Chaska describe the same acres in opposite terms. Using one detail from each column, explain how the Homestead Act could be a genuine promise and a genuine injustice at the same time.

Show what you know:

- Write a two-voice journal entry: the same day on the plains, once as Anna and once as Chaska.
 - Annotate the Golden Spike photo - add who is NOT in the frame, and why.
 - Record a 60-second 'both are true' explainer for a younger student.
-

Spread 2 • US.02

Analyze how the reservation system, the Dawes Act, and boarding schools sought to dissolve Native landholding and identity through forced assimilation.

🔊 New rules at your new school: they hold you down and cut your hair, hand you a brand-new name, and punish you every single time you speak the language your mom taught you. All of it — they promise — is for your own good. This wasn't a horror movie. It was the United States government's official plan for Native kids, and thousands of them, your age, lived it.

Archive sets the crew down at a boarding-school gate, hundreds of miles from any reservation. Kids arrive in their own clothes; weeks later they walk out looking like someone the school approved of. Spark holds up two photographs of the same boy. 'Same kid. Three years apart,' he says quietly. 'This one picture tells you what "assimilation" actually meant.'



ERA-FRIEND

Chaska • a home cut into squares, a self cut to fit

First they shrank Chaska's whole world down to a reservation. Then a law called the Dawes Act sliced even that into 160-acre squares and sold off the leftovers to settlers. The men who wrote it called it a gift — private property would 'civilize' his people into farmers and citizens. But his people never held land as separate squares. They held it together, the way you hold hands. Then came the school: his hair cut, his language banned, his name swapped for one a stranger could pronounce. The policy didn't just take acres. It reached for the idea of belonging to one another — and tried to cut that off too.



ERA-FRIEND

Anna • the cost she couldn't see before

Anna thinks about her own school — where she kept her name, kept her language, and walked home to her own family every night. Then she looks at the two photographs: the same boy, long hair and his people's clothes, then a stiff collar and a soldier's haircut, three years apart. And the price of her family's fresh start finally has a face. The 'progress' she cheered on the plains was, for a kid like Chaska, a machine built to erase him. Anna doesn't look away. She lets it change how she tells the story of the West — which is the bravest thing she does in this entire unit.

PRIMARY VOICE

Zitkala-Sa (Yankton Dakota) - in her own words

Chaska is a stand-in — but this happened to a real girl, and she wrote it down so nobody could say they didn't know. Zitkala-Sa was eight years old when she was taken from her mother and put on a train to a faraway school. In her own account, she remembers being tied to a chair while they sheared off her long hair — hair her people cut only in mourning or shame. 'I lost my spirit,' she wrote. They forbade her language and traded away her name. And then she grew up to become a writer, a musician, and a fighter for Native rights — living proof that the kids those schools tried to erase did not disappear. When you read Chaska, listen for her underneath him.



 J. N. Choate's before-and-after portraits of Navajo student Tom Torlino at the Carlisle Indian Industrial School — the most reproduced propaganda image of federal assimilation policy.

Choate, John N. Tom Torlino, Navajo, Before and After. 1882 and 1885. Photographs. Richard Henry Pratt Papers, Beinecke Library, Yale University.

 The school made this image to show 'success.' Who made it, and why? What does it prove — and what does it hide about what was done to the child in it?

In plain words: The U.S. government tried to erase Native cultures. The Dawes Act (1887) broke up shared tribal land into small private plots and sold off the rest. Boarding schools cut children's hair, banned their languages, and changed their names. Leaders called it 'assimilation' and a gift - but it caused deep harm and huge land loss.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee knew this policy firsthand a generation earlier. East Tennessee was Cherokee homeland - Sequoyah, who created the Cherokee writing system, lived there - until the U.S. forced the Cherokee out in the 1838 Trail of Tears. The removal Chaska is living through on the Plains had already played out on Tennessee's own ground.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Federal policy set out to erase Native landholding and identity through allotment and boarding schools.
- **Head out of the sand:** Native families and children who lived it, and a few reform writers who publicized it.
- **Voice raised:** Native resistance and survival, and reform writing and testimony that put the schools and the Dawes Act before the public.
- **Government response:** Here the government was the SOURCE of the harm - the era's federal policy deepened dispossession. Meaningful correction did not come for decades.
- **Still unfinished:** Land, sovereignty, language, and the reckoning with the boarding schools remain open questions today.

✓ **Check:** Reformers called the boarding schools and the Dawes Act a benefit to Native people. Give the intended goal and the actual effect of this assimilation policy.

Show what you know:

- Write a letter Chaska might hide from the school, in his own words.
 - Create a 'read against the maker' caption for the Torlino photo: what it wants you to think vs. what it actually shows.
 - Map the Trail of Tears route out of East Tennessee and connect it to federal Plains policy.
-

Spread 3 • US.03

Explain how the Compromise of 1877 ended Reconstruction and enabled Jim Crow, and evaluate the Freedmen's Bureau's intended role through a period cartoon.

🔊 Picture the refs strolling off the field at halftime — and the other team gets to write the rules for the next eighty years. That's about what 1877 did to the American South. And when three Black businessmen in Memphis ran a grocery store that competed a little too well, a mob murdered them for it. One of their friends — a young journalist named Ida B. Wells — decided the whole country was going to hear about it.

Archive flies south, then drops the crew at a New York newsstand. 'Isaiah packed up and left the South,' she says. 'Let's find out what he left behind — and how a kid a thousand miles north found out about it.'



ERA-FRIEND

Isaiah • why he left the South

Isaiah remembers when a federal Bureau still stood between his family and the men who wanted them back in chains. Then, in 1877, a backroom deal to settle a disputed election pulled the last federal troops out of the South. The men who had lost the war took back the state governments and started writing Jim Crow into law — segregation on paper, and a slow, quiet strangling of the Black vote. That was the day Isaiah stopped waiting. He joined the Exodusters heading for Kansas behind a Nashville man named Pap Singleton, because freedom in the South had become a promise with the guards quietly sent home.



ERA-FRIEND

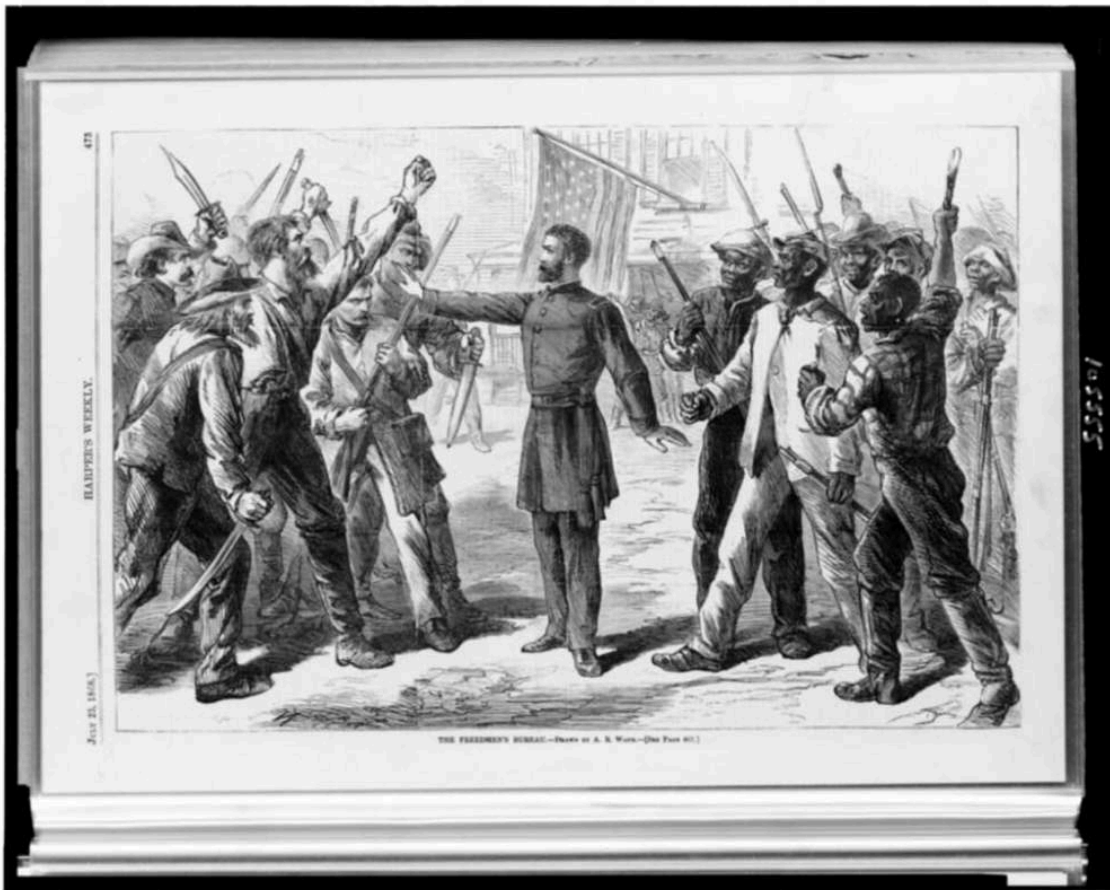
Frankie • what the papers showed

Frankie hawks newspapers on a Manhattan corner, and lately every front page is the South. He keeps coming back to one engraving: a Freedmen's Bureau officer with his arms flung wide, holding back an armed white mob on one side and armed Black men defending their homes on the other. At first Frankie figured it was a faraway problem, none of his business. But the pictures keep coming, and now the headlines say the soldiers are leaving. And a fourteen-year-old newsboy starts turning over the question most grown men were busy dodging: what happens to people when the country that swore to protect them just... stops?

PRIMARY VOICE

Ida B. Wells (Memphis) - in her own words

Some people leave. Some people flat-out refuse to be quiet. In Memphis, a young Black editor named Ida B. Wells lost three friends — the owners of the People's Grocery — to a lynch mob in 1892. She didn't swallow the official story. She investigated, and what she found was uglier and simpler than anyone wanted in print: lynching wasn't about punishing crime, it was about crushing Black success and keeping Black people afraid. She published it anyway. A mob smashed her newspaper office and warned her never to set foot in Tennessee again. She kept writing. 'The way to right wrongs,' she said, 'is to turn the light of truth upon them.' She was in her twenties.



📷 Alfred R. Waud's July 25, 1868 Harper's Weekly engraving of a Freedmen's Bureau officer holding apart armed white and Black men — a visual argument for federal protection.

Waud, Alfred R. "The Freedmen's Bureau." Harper's Weekly, July 25, 1868, 473. Library of Congress Prints and Photographs Division.

💡 This cartoon argues the Bureau was needed to keep the peace. After 1877 that federal figure is withdrawn. Predict, from the image, what the artist would expect to happen next — and then check it against Isaiah's experience.

In plain words: The Compromise of 1877 ended Reconstruction by pulling federal troops out of the South. White Southern governments then passed Jim Crow laws - segregation and rules that blocked Black people from voting. Many Black Southerners, like Isaiah, left; others, like Ida B. Wells, stayed and fought back.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee was at the center of this story. In 1881 Tennessee passed one of the nation's earliest 'separate car' laws segregating railroads. In Memphis, a young Black journalist named Ida B. Wells launched a national anti-lynching campaign after the 1892 lynching of three of her friends at the People's Grocery - a Tennessee writer in her twenties taking on the whole country.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** After Reconstruction, lynching and Jim Crow terrorized Black Southerners while the federal government looked away.
- **Head out of the sand:** Ida B. Wells, after three of her friends were lynched at the People's Grocery in Memphis in 1892.
- **Voice raised:** Investigative journalism and the press (Wells's anti-lynching writing), plus the Exodusters' 'voting with their feet' by leaving the South.
- **Government response:** Almost none at the federal level in this era - the response was delayed for generations.
- **Still unfinished:** A federal anti-lynching law did not pass until 2022 - proof that raising a voice does not guarantee a fast fix, and that some climbs take more than a century.

✓ **Check:** The Compromise of 1877 is often described as the 'end of Reconstruction.' Explain what changed for Black Southerners like Isaiah when federal troops withdrew, using the cartoon and Isaiah's column as evidence.

Show what you know:

- Write the headline and first paragraph Ida B. Wells might publish about her friends' deaths.
 - Build a cause-and-effect chain from 'troops leave (1877)' to 'Jim Crow law' to 'Isaiah leaves.'
 - Debate: was leaving (the Exodusters) or staying and fighting (Wells) the braver choice? Defend it with evidence.
-

Spread 4 • US.04

Analyze Gilded Age politics and economics — the power of trusts and machines and the divide between capitalists and wage earners — using a period cartoon.

💡 There's always a group that you're not in — the one where the real decisions actually get made. In 1889 a cartoonist drew America's version of it: the U.S. Senate, packed with giant money-bags labeled OIL, STEEL, and SUGAR looming over tiny little senators — and the door marked 'PEOPLE'S ENTRANCE' bolted shut. It went viral, 1889-style, because everybody already knew it was true.

Archive lands the crew in the gallery above the Senate floor. 'On paper, this is the people's house,' she says. 'Spark — show them who actually owns the room.' He unrolls a cartoon that made the whole country furious.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • who really runs the room

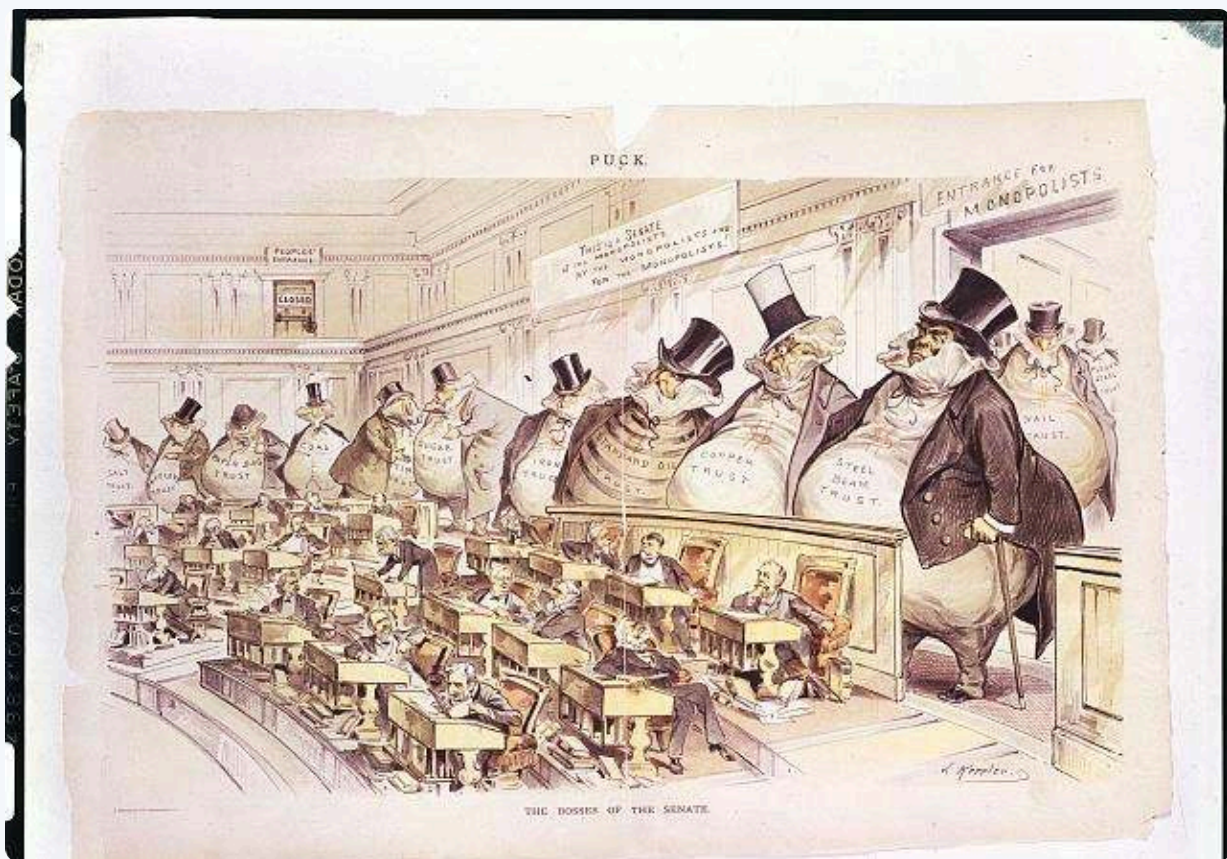
Frankie knows exactly how his city runs: the machine hands you coal in winter, a job for your cousin, a turkey at Christmas — and in return it owns your vote and runs everything. So the cartoon lands for him instantly. Money-bags the size of buildings — OIL, STEEL, SUGAR, COAL — crowd the Senate floor while the senators scurry underneath like clerks, and the 'People's Entrance' hangs padlocked. To Frankie it isn't an exaggeration. It's just his own block drawn big: the people with the money get the government, and everybody else waits at a locked door.



ERA-FRIEND

Isaiah • the locked door, again

Isaiah looks at that bolted 'People's Entrance' and feels it land in his chest. He's already lived one version of being shut out — a vote made too dangerous to cast, a Bureau packed up and sent home. Now he sees a second lock on a second door: an economy where a handful of industrialists own the wealth while farmers drown in debt and workers take whatever wage they're handed. The Gilded Age glittered at the top, Isaiah decides, precisely because so many people were kept outside the room where the deals got made. Two different locks. Same feeling.

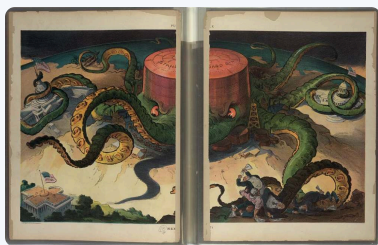


📷 Joseph Keppler's 1889 Puck cartoon showing industrial trusts as money-bag giants towering over tiny senators — the Gilded Age's most famous indictment of corporate capture.

Keppler, Joseph. "The Bosses of the Senate." Puck, January 23, 1889. Library of Congress Prints and Photographs Division.

💡 List every label the artist put on the moneybags, then find the 'People's Entrance.' What argument is the cartoonist making by drawing the sizes the way he did?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



Udo Keppler's September 7, 1904 Puck cartoon depicting Standard Oil as an octopus strangling American industry and reaching for the White House.

In plain words: In the Gilded Age, a few huge companies (trusts) and city 'machines' held enormous power over the government. A famous 1889 cartoon showed money bags towering over tiny senators while ordinary people were locked out. Meanwhile, rich industrialists thrived as farmers and workers struggled.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee lived the 'workers locked out' side of the Gilded Age. In 1891-1892, free coal miners in East Tennessee's Coal Creek rose up against the convict-lease system - the state was renting out prisoners to mine owners to replace paid workers. The 'Coal Creek War' was Tennessee's own fight over who really holds power in an industrial economy. And it worked: after the uprising, Tennessee refused to renew its convict-lease contract and ended the practice by the mid-1890s - a real problem, a real protest, a real policy change.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A handful of trusts and monopolies gained enormous, largely unchecked power over the government and the economy.
- **Head out of the sand:** Farmers, wage earners, and a public stirred by journalists and cartoonists.
- **Voice raised:** The press and political cartoons ('The Bosses of the Senate'), public outrage, and the vote; in Tennessee, the Coal Creek miners' armed protest.
- **Government response:** Congress passed the Sherman Antitrust Act (1890), the first federal law against monopolies; in Tennessee, the state ended the convict-lease system by the mid-1890s.
- **Still unfinished:** Enforcement was weak at first, and the fight over corporate power in politics is still going.

✓ **Check:** In 'The Bosses of the Senate,' the trusts are drawn as giants and the senators as tiny figures, with the 'People's Entrance' bolted shut. What is the cartoonist arguing about Gilded Age government, and which groups are left powerless?

Show what you know:

- Redraw 'The Bosses of the Senate' for today - what would the money bags be labeled?
 - Write Isaiah's and Frankie's one-line definitions of 'the locked door' and explain how they differ.
 - Research and summarize, in your own words, one demand of the Coal Creek miners.
-

Spread 5 • US.05

Describe how industrial leaders and innovations transformed American life, and weigh the Gospel of Wealth against the conditions of the workers who produced that wealth.

🔔 A billionaire posts about donating a hospital wing — while the people who actually built his fortune can't cover rent. Real generosity, or a really good PR move? America had this exact fight in 1889, and even gave it a name: the Gospel of Wealth. Scroll your feed; you've already seen this week's version.

Archive sets down beside an oil refinery burning bright against the night, lit up like a small city. 'This is the other face of the Gilded Age,' she says. 'The invention, the fortune, and a whole philosophy that said the fortune was a gift to the rest of us. Spark — show them what the public actually thought of that.'



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • dazzled, then doubtful

Frankie is dazzled, and honestly, who wouldn't be — electric light turning midnight into noon, a voice flying down a wire, whole warehouses of goods a regular family could suddenly afford. And he's read that the richest man in steel says a great fortune is really a public trust, that a rich man is just a caretaker who owes every dollar back in libraries and schools. It sounds noble. Then Spark unrolls the octopus: Standard Oil drawn as a giant creature, one tentacle wrapped around Congress, another reaching for the White House. And Frankie starts to wonder whether a gift handed down from that much power is a gift at all — or just the crumbs off a stranglehold.



ERA-FRIEND

Rosa • who paid for the wealth

Rosa sews shirtwaists twelve hours a day for a wage that barely covers a shared room. She's got nothing against libraries — she'd kill for the free time to sit in one. But she spots the catch in the Gospel of Wealth: the 'gift' is decided entirely by the giver, and only after the people who made the fortune have been paid as little as the market will allow. The same monopoly muscle the octopus cartoon mocks is exactly what sets her hours and her pay. To Rosa, generosity that shows up only after the wage has been squeezed isn't the whole story of the Gilded Age. It's just the part that photographs well.

PRIMARY VOICE

Andrew Carnegie · the industrialist's own case

It's only fair to let the man speak for himself. Andrew Carnegie would tell Rosa and Frankie he's not their enemy — he's their benefactor. In his own essay he argues that the man of wealth is merely a trustee for the public good: live modestly, provide for your family in moderation, and pour the rest — in your own lifetime — into libraries, schools, and concert halls the whole city can use. Competition is brutal on the individual, he admits, but he insists it's best for the human race, because it gathers capital in the hands of the few who know how to use it. Hear him out, all the way. Then weigh his case against the octopus — and against Rosa's rent.



📷 Udo Keppler's 1904 Puck cartoon depicting Standard Oil as an octopus strangling American industry and reaching for the White House.

Keppler, Udo J. "Next!" Puck 56, no. 1436 (September 7, 1904). Library of Congress Prints and Photographs Division.

💡 Trace each tentacle to what it grips. The Gospel of Wealth says the industrialist is a generous steward; the cartoon says he is an octopus. Can both be describing the same men? How would you decide which is truer?

In plain words: New inventions (electric light, the telephone) and giant companies transformed daily life. Andrew Carnegie's 'Gospel of Wealth' said the rich should give their fortunes back through libraries and schools. Critics drew Standard Oil as an octopus strangling the country. Was the wealth a gift - or squeezed from underpaid workers like Rosa?

● **Tennessee:** One of the era's most famous products got its start in Tennessee. In 1899, two businessmen bought the bottling rights to Coca-Cola and opened the very first bottling plant in Chattanooga - turning a soda-fountain drink into a product shipped everywhere. Tennessee wasn't just watching the new economy; it helped build one of its icons.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Standard Oil grew into a monopoly powerful enough to dictate prices and reach into government.
- **Head out of the sand:** Consumers, small competitors, and a public alarmed by muckraking journalism and cartoons.
- **Voice raised:** Journalism and political cartoons ('Next!'), building on the antitrust movement.
- **Government response:** Using the Sherman Antitrust Act, the Supreme Court ordered Standard Oil broken up in 1911.
- **Still unfinished:** New monopolies and the question of how big is too big keep the debate alive.

✓ **Check:** Andrew Carnegie's 'Gospel of Wealth' and the 'Next!' cartoon describe the same industrialists very differently. Make a claim about how much the Gospel of Wealth justified Gilded Age inequality, cite both sources, and explain your reasoning.

Show what you know:

- Write a modern 'Gospel of Wealth' post from a tech billionaire - then Rosa's reply.
 - Annotate the octopus cartoon: label each tentacle and what it controls.
 - Make a T-chart weighing philanthropy against worker wages, then write your verdict.
-

Spread 6 • US.06

Analyze how industrialization and immigration drove the growth of major industrial cities and shaped urban labor and living conditions.

💡 Your town runs on people who can't afford to live in it — the drivers, the cooks, the crew cleaning the building at five in the morning. That's not some new glitch. In 1900, America built its greatest cities on the muscle of immigrants it then refused to house. Rosa was one of them, and she can show you both the promise and the price.

Archive brings the crew down into the Great Hall at Ellis Island, a room roaring with a dozen languages at once. 'Twelve million people will pass through a room like this,' she says. 'Where they went next built the modern American city.'



ERA-FRIEND

Rosa • through the Great Hall

Rosa still remembers the Great Hall — the flags strung from the ceiling, the long benches, the doctors reading every face for anyone too sick to let through. She came because the factories and docks and rail yards of the big cities were starving for hands, and hers were willing. New York, Chicago, Pittsburgh — each one swelled into a giant because the work piled up there, and the workers piled up wherever the work was. Rosa is proud she passed inspection and had a job inside a week. She's less proud of the room she sleeps in. And she's already learning the city's quiet arithmetic: it needed her labor, and it never once planned to house it.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • the city that never stops

Frankie was born into the machine Rosa is just stepping inside. He knows its rhythm cold — the factory whistles, the jammed streetcars, the tenements stacked with families from every corner of the earth. He shows Rosa a census map shaded dark where the foreign-born crowd thickest, and it lines up exactly with the blocks where the mills and the docks are. To Frankie the city is an engine that runs on newcomers: it needs their labor to grow, and it grows way too fast to take care of the people making it grow. He can't decide whether that makes his city cruel, or just hungry.

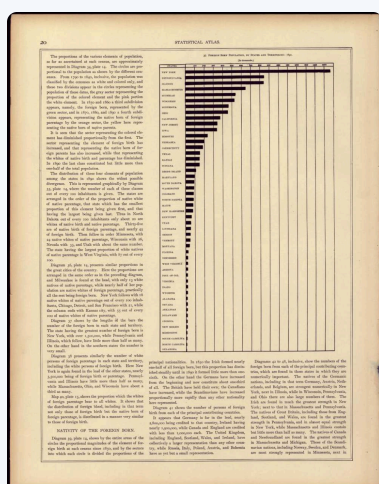


📷 The inspection room at Ellis Island, where more than twelve million immigrants were processed between 1892 and 1954.

Detroit Publishing Company. Inspection Room, Ellis Island, New York. Ca. 1910-1920. Photograph. Library of Congress Prints and Photographs Division.

💡 Look at the scale of this room and the benches lined up for processing. What does the size and order of the space tell you about how the country saw the millions of people passing through it?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



The U.S. Census 'Foreign Born Population, 1890' map — foreign-born residents cluster darkest in the industrial Northeast and Upper Midwest.

In plain words: Factories, ports, and railroads made cities like New York, Chicago, and Pittsburgh explode in size. Immigrants like Rosa came through Ellis Island to fill those jobs and settled where the work was - but the cities that needed their labor often didn't provide decent housing. Immigration and city growth fed each other.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee's industrial growth had its own hard edges. The 1878 yellow fever epidemic devastated Memphis, killing thousands and driving out so many residents that the city temporarily surrendered its charter. In the East Tennessee coalfields, the Coal Creek War exposed how brutal industrial labor could be. Tennessee cities lived the same boom-and-crisis story as the big industrial centers.

✓ **Check:** Using the Ellis Island photograph and the 1890 foreign-born map, explain the relationship between immigration and the growth of America's industrial cities.

Show what you know:

- Use the 1890 foreign-born map to write two sentences on where immigrants settled and why.
 - Design an Ellis Island 'welcome vs. warning' poster showing both sides of the city's promise.
 - Interview a classmate in role as Rosa and Frankie about what a city owes the people who build it.
-

Spread 7 • US.07

Compare 'old' and 'new' immigrants and analyze nativist responses, using a period photograph of tenement conditions.

🔊 Same person steps off the boat. One country calls them an 'expat.' Another calls them an 'immigrant.' Another calls them a 'problem.' Same human, three different welcomes — and the difference comes down mostly to where they're from and what they look like, not anything they actually did. America built that sorting machine in the 1890s, splitting newcomers into the 'good' kind and the 'threat.'

Last stop. Archive follows Rosa home to a Bayard Street block, and sets Anna down beside her — the Norwegian girl from the plains, all grown into her own story. 'Two immigrants,' Archive says. 'One generation apart. Watch how differently the country decided to see them.'



ERA-FRIEND

Rosa • a 'new' immigrant

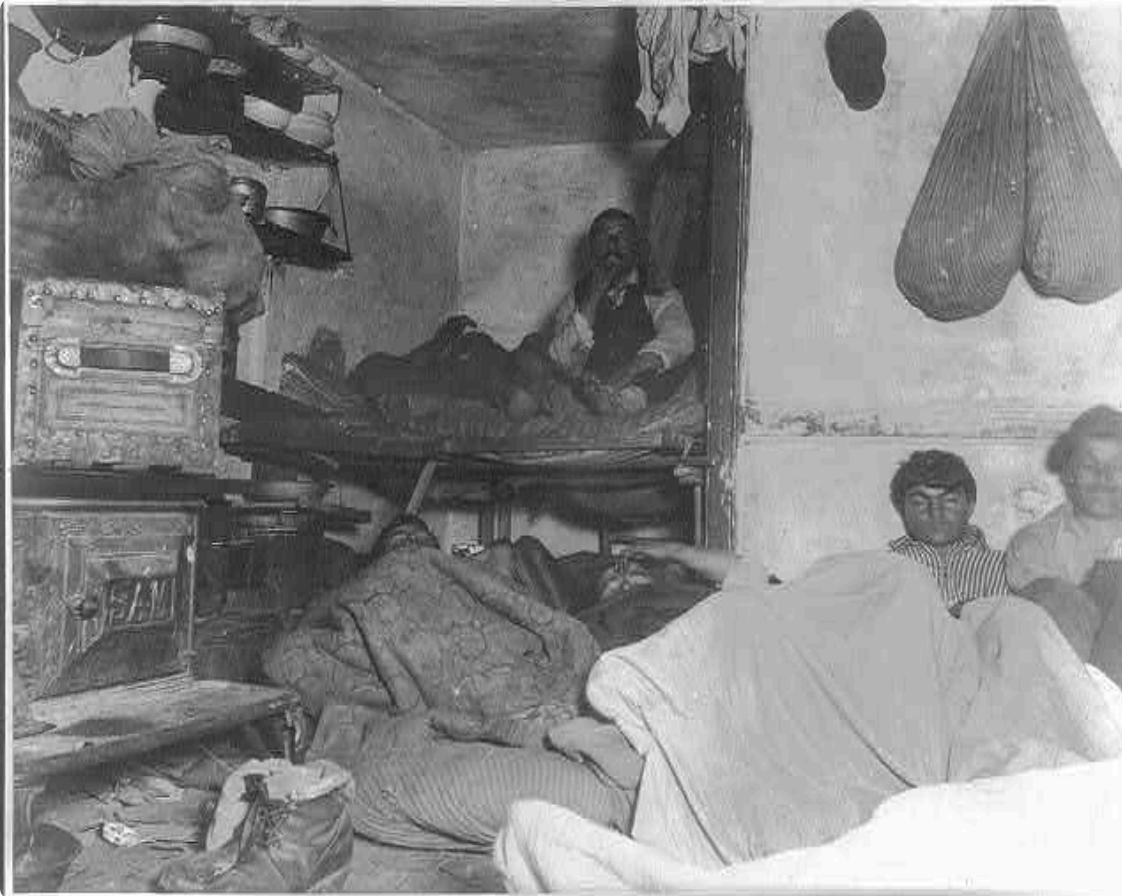
Rosa is what the newspapers call a 'new' immigrant — southern Italian, Catholic, speaking a language most of her neighbors can't. Reformers photograph her block to shame the city into fixing it, and she's grateful; maybe the pictures buy her clean water and a little light. But she can hear the other message humming underneath some of them — that people like her are the problem, not the landlord charging six families for one airless room. She works. She pays. She believes in this country. And she can feel the door she came through starting to swing shut behind her.



ERA-FRIEND

Anna • an 'old' immigrant, looking back

Anna's family were immigrants too — Norwegian, Protestant, northern European. They broke their backs on the plains. But the country called them 'settlers,' and handed them land. Standing in Rosa's tenement now, Anna finally sees how much of her own welcome she never actually earned — how much of it came down to where she was born and the color she is. She was an immigrant the country decided to rename a 'pioneer.' Rosa is an immigrant the country decided to call a threat. And that line between 'old' and 'new,' Anna realizes, was never really about how hard anybody worked. It was about who America had already made up its mind to trust.



📷 Jacob Riis's 1889 flash photograph of a Bayard Street lodging house, published in *How the Other Half Lives* (1890) — the image that forced middle-class America to see tenement poverty.

Riis, Jacob A. *Five Cents a Spot*. 1889. Photograph. Library of Congress Prints and Photographs Division.

💡 Riis photographed this to demand reform. But the same image could be used to blame the immigrants in it. How can one photograph carry two opposite messages — and how do you tell what the photographer intended?

In plain words: Americans divided immigrants into 'old' (Northern and Western Europeans, like Anna) and 'new' (Southern and Eastern Europeans and Asians, like Rosa). 'New' immigrants faced nativism - hostility and blame - and crowded tenements like the one Jacob Riis photographed. The difference in welcome was often about origin and religion, not effort.

● **Tennessee:** The 1890 census map tells Tennessee's immigration story at a glance: the South, including Tennessee, is shaded light - it had a small foreign-born population compared with Northern industrial cities. The 'new immigration' mostly flowed north, so Tennesseans experienced this era's biggest debate more from a distance - though Memphis and Nashville did have small Italian, Irish, and German communities.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** 'New' immigrants crowded into dangerous, overcrowded tenements while facing nativist blame.
- **Head out of the sand:** Reformers and the public, once photographs made the conditions impossible to ignore.
- **Voice raised:** Documentary photography and journalism - Jacob Riis's 'How the Other Half Lives' put tenement poverty in front of middle-class America.
- **Government response:** New York's Tenement House Act of 1901 required light, ventilation, and indoor plumbing in new buildings - an early Progressive housing reform.
- **Still unfinished:** Housing, immigration, and who belongs are still argued in every generation.

✓ **Check:** Return to the essential question: whose America was being built, and at whose expense? Make a claim, cite evidence from at least two different spreads (including at least one image), and explain how opportunity and loss could be two sides of the same industrial expansion.

Show what you know:

- Write Anna's honest admission to Rosa about the welcome she got - and didn't earn.
 - Use the Riis photo to argue both messages it could send, then decide which the photographer intended.
 - Map today's version of 'old vs. new' immigrant language and compare it to 1890.
-

Toward a more perfect union

This unit is one chapter of a project older than any of us - the one the Constitution names in its first line: forming 'a more perfect union.' You'll meet Americans the country failed and Americans it lifted, often in the very same years. The nation wasn't perfect then and isn't now. Your job isn't to decide it was simply good or bad - it's to watch how it moved, and to make up your own mind, from the evidence, about which direction.

Closing question: Look for a pattern across these seven stories: a problem gets ignored until it hurts people badly enough that someone refuses to stay silent - and their voice (a photograph, a newspaper, a strike, a vote) pushes the government to act. Sometimes the fix came fast (the Sherman Antitrust Act; Tennessee ending convict leasing). Sometimes it took generations (a federal anti-lynching law). Sometimes the government itself caused the harm (federal Indian policy). Choose two moments from this unit and argue, with evidence: in these years, did the country climb toward a 'more perfect union,' or slip back? There is no answer key - defend yours.

This unit on the Arc of the Union

You decide: did each of these move the country **toward** its founding promise of liberty and equality for all — or away from it? There's no answer key — mark your own read and defend it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1869	Homestead Act & transcontinental railroad	Free land and a coast-to-coast railroad opened the West to millions - and drove the dispossession of Native nations.	
1877	Compromise of 1877 ends Reconstruction	Federal troops leave the South, opening the door to Jim Crow.	
1881	Tennessee's separate-car law	One of the nation's earliest Jim Crow railroad-segregation statutes.	

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1887	Dawes Act	Breaks up tribal land and accelerates Native dispossession under the banner of 'assimilation.'	
1890	Sherman Antitrust Act	Public outrage at the trusts produces the first federal law against monopoly.	
1892	Ida B. Wells's anti-lynching campaign	A Memphis journalist turns the light of truth on lynching.	
1896	Tennessee ends convict leasing	After the Coal Creek War, Tennessee stops leasing prisoners to private mines.	
1901	NY Tenement House Act	Reform photography helps win light, air, and plumbing for tenements.	
1911	Standard Oil broken up	The Supreme Court uses the Sherman Act to dismantle the monopoly.	